

Key Philosophers & Thinkers in *Education*

Indian knowledge traditions & six visionary thinkers

DR. JUHI SIDHARTH and
DR. SHIVAKUMAR JOLLAD

PART ONE

Indian knowledge traditions

A culture of doubt, dialogue, and lived knowing — the soil from which these thinkers grew.

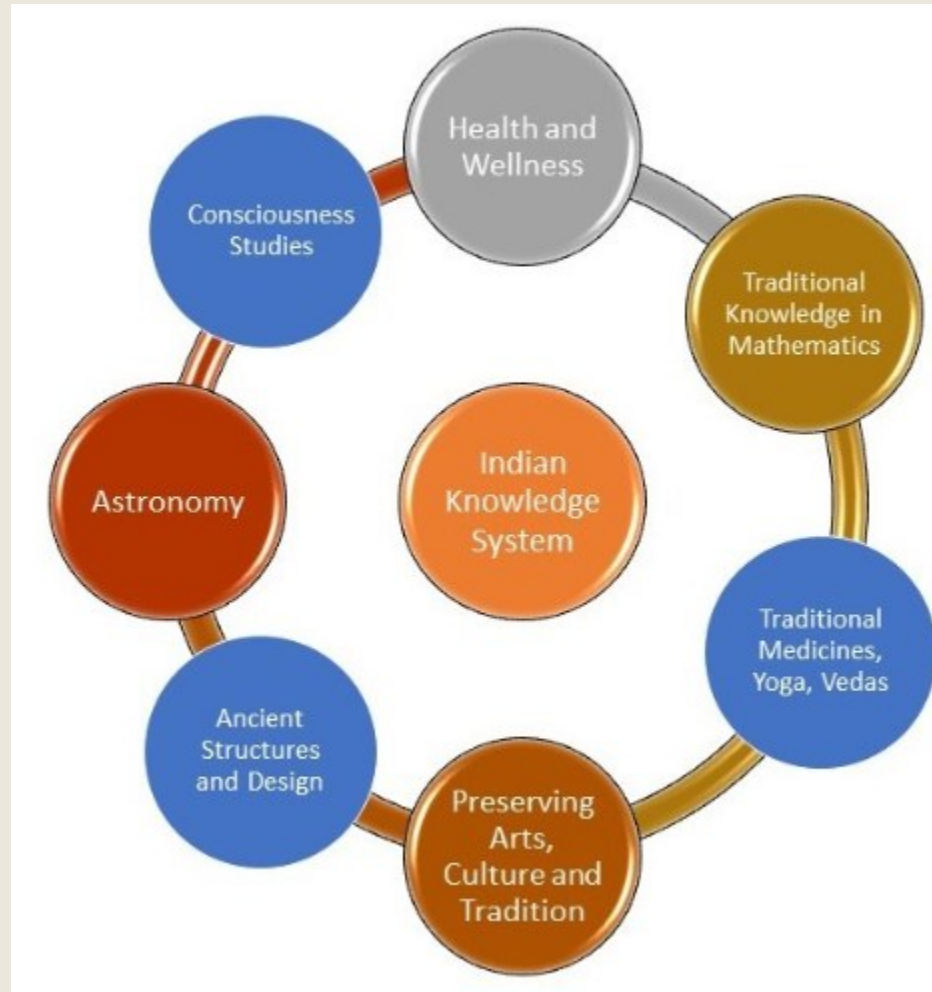
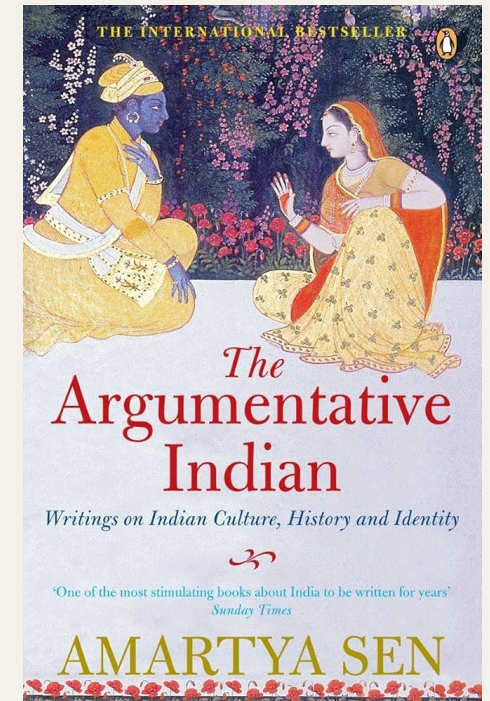
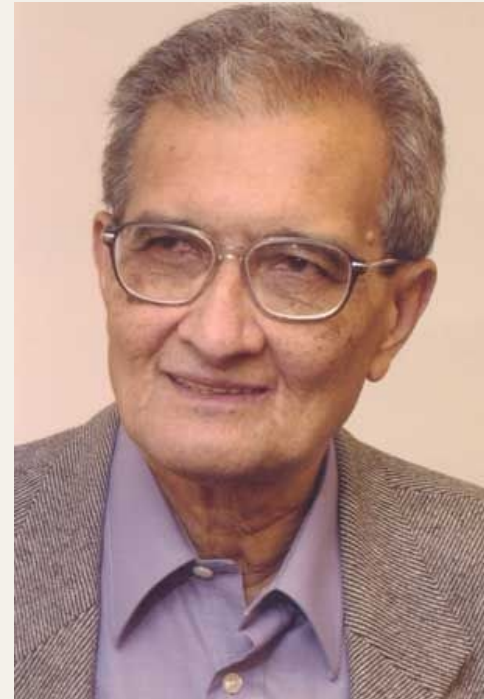


Image source: <https://radiancenews.com/indian-knowledge-system-an-overview/>

A tradition built on doubt, not certainty

Amartya Sen finds a “powerful presence of religious *scepticism*” in India — against the cliché that reads Indian culture as essentially religious. The *shastrarth* were living spaces for critique, change, and reinterpretation, as were the Upanishadic dialogues and the Bhagavad Gita.

Sen 2005, p. 22



Some knowledge is lived, not merely learned

KNOWING-THAT

Justified true belief — the facts.

KNOWING-HOW

Skill, practice, acquaintance.

KNOWING-AS-BEING

Ideas realized by *living* them, not just thinking them.

To know a society anthropologically is to grant that its truths are often inhabited before they are explained.

Wisdom spoken to peasants, women, and the lower castes

The secular poetry of Tukaram, Kabir, Nanak, and Bulle Shah spoke in “homely metaphors, from the heart of the ordinary.” In them, the “seemingly irreconcilable opposites” — the spiritual and the social — coexist and mutually nourish one another.

TUKARAM

KABIR

NANAK

BULLE SHAH

“Modernity is *plural*.”

These visionary anticolonial intellectuals critiqued and restructured the social, cultural, religious, and political life of Indian society — “with a surprising degree of intellectual sophistication and confidence,” through a mediated critique of their own traditions, both old and new.

Kaviraj 2000, p. 146

Six visionary thinkers

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|----|---------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 01 | M.K. Gandhi | <i>Swaraj & the craft school</i> |
| 02 | B.R. Ambedkar | <i>Educate, organize, agitate</i> |
| 03 | Swami Vivekananda | <i>All knowledge is within</i> |
| 04 | Rabindranath Tagore | <i>The whole person, through art</i> |
| 05 | Jiddu Krishnamurti | <i>A school without conditioning</i> |
| 06 | Sri Aurobindo | <i>Integral education</i> |
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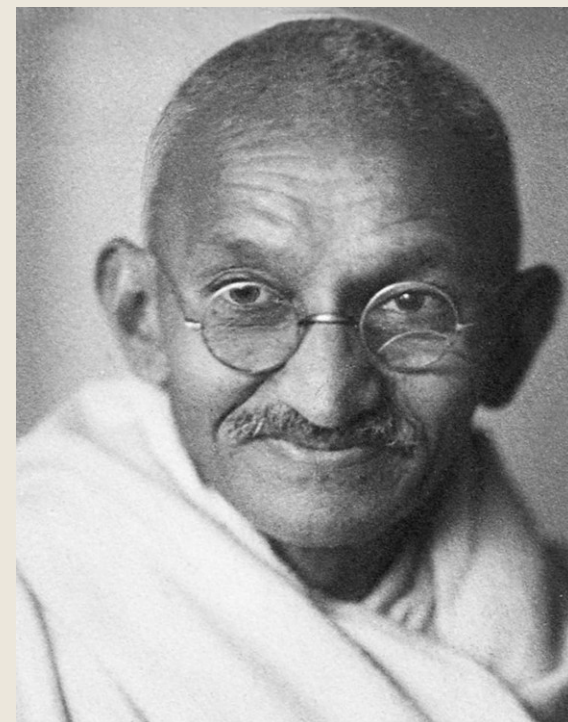
THINKER 01 / 06

M.K. Gandhi

1869 – 1948

Satyagraha and Ahimsa, ever-evolving — anchored in the conviction that *man is intrinsically good*.

He rejected two most prevalent assumptions about human nature, viz. the Hobbesian assumption that humans are essentially barbaric and the Marxist assumption that human nature is socially constructed (Doctor [1992](#)).



M.K. GANDHI

01

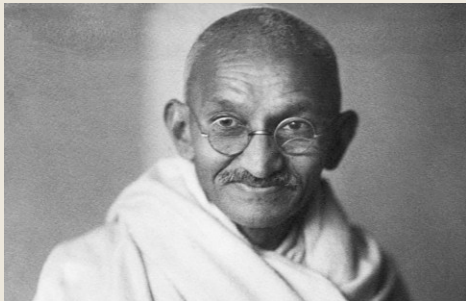
M.K. Gandhi

1869–1948

A SPIRITUAL FORCE

Moral progress, powered by a spiritual vision

Like Kant, Gandhi believed moral progress was inevitable for man. But where Kant's engine was pure reason, Gandhi's was a *Darsana* — “an insight into the nature of reality.” Religion supplied the strength to act morally, turning every action into a “prayerful-act” that fuses the spiritual, the moral, and the practical.

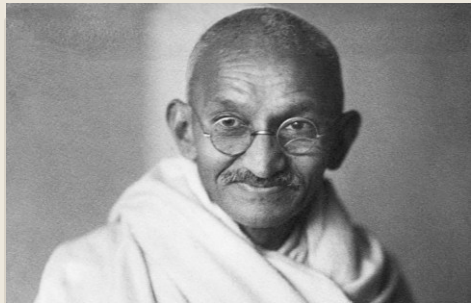


Dalvi 2007 · Goyal 2019 · Chandra 2018

01

M.K. Gandhi

1869–1948



SWARAJ

Ruling oneself, freeing the other

The community

A “cooperative commonwealth of responsible members” — each self-reliant and self-disciplined.

The individual

Each becomes “his/her own ruler,” ruling so the other's freedom is never hindered — until police, military, and state “wither away.”

Gandhi 1909/1939 · Kabir 1955 · Jahanbegloo & Lama 2013

O1

M.K. Gandhi

Nai Talim

NAI TALIM · BASIC EDUCATION

Craft as the organizing principle of the curriculum

History, arithmetic, geography — every subject taught *through* a chosen local handicraft, so school and the world outside are bridged.

Self-reliance

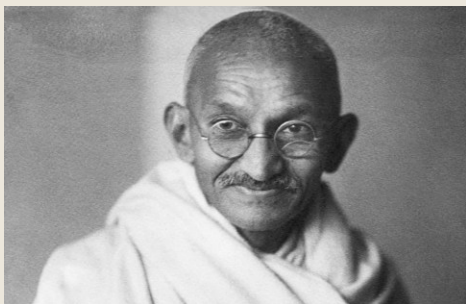
A school that financially sustains itself, free of the state.

Participation

Consented, creative work socializes the child into cooperation.

Dignity of labour

Crafts mirror society; the child learns the many-sidedness of life.



Kumar 2005 · Sethi 2009 · Jahanbegloo 2013

THINKER 02 / 06

B.R. Ambedkar

1891 – 1956

Lived experience of caste and a Western education met in a “*reconstructive present*” — where education and politics are inseparable.



Dr. B R Ambedkar
Image source: wiki

“

Nothing can achieve this except the spread of higher education. This, in my opinion, is the *panacea of our social troubles* .

Coming from the lowest order of Hindu society, Ambedkar knew its value — not to feed or clothe the oppressed, but to remove the inferiority “which has stunted their growth and made them slaves to others.”

B.R. AMBEDKAR — cited in Paik 2014, p. 93

02

B.R. Ambedkar

1891–1956



BEYOND FORMAL SCHOOLING

Educate · Organize · *Agitate*

Reading his Columbia teacher John Dewey, Ambedkar embraced “reconstruction” — but deliberately went beyond formal education. Schools mattered, yet “mass organizing, social centres, and political speeches” were “equally or probably more valuable.” His ideas on education cannot be read apart from his politics.

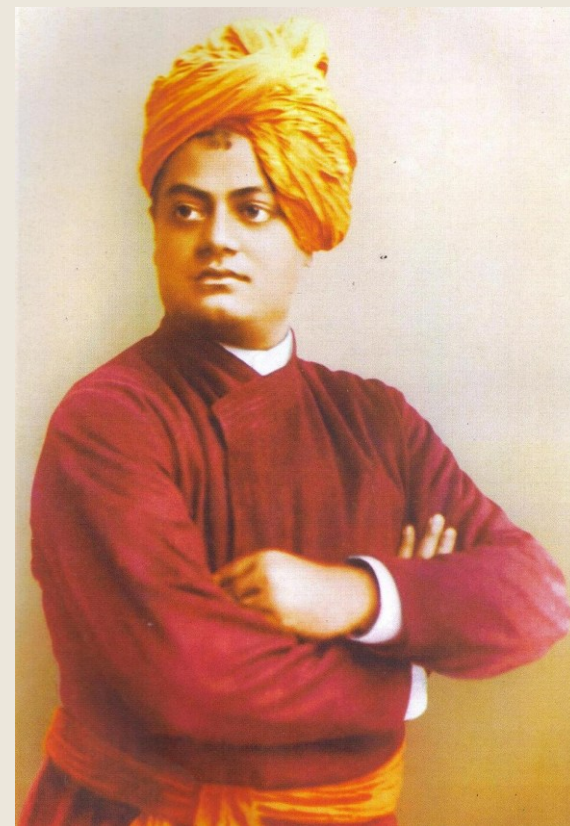
Stroud 2017, p. 91 · Rege 2010

THINKER 03 / 06

Swami Vivekananda

1863 – 1902

An education rooted in Indian civilization — a
reasoned faith uniting science and spirituality.



Swami Vivekananda
Image source: wiki

03

Swami Vivekananda

1863–1902



ALL KNOWLEDGE IS WITHIN

“Knowledge was not in matter; it was in man all the time.”

The self already holds all knowledge; education focuses the mind — by the strength of the will, and through the eightfold path of Yoga — to manifest it. So *schooling* must be distinguished from *education*:

SCHOOLING

Learning to know · learning to do

EDUCATION

Learning to be

Vivekananda 1962, vol. II, p. 339 · Monto 2010

THINKER 04 / 06

Rabindranath Tagore

1861 – 1941

Schooling that serves the *growth of the child* —
dissolving the binaries of East and West, rural
and urban.

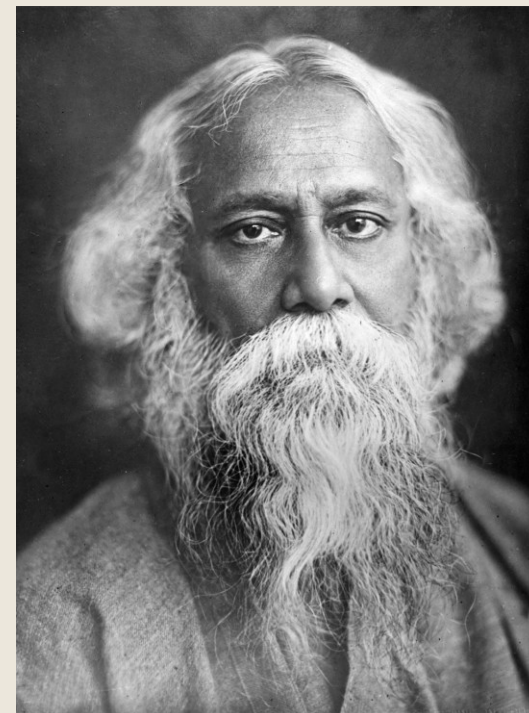
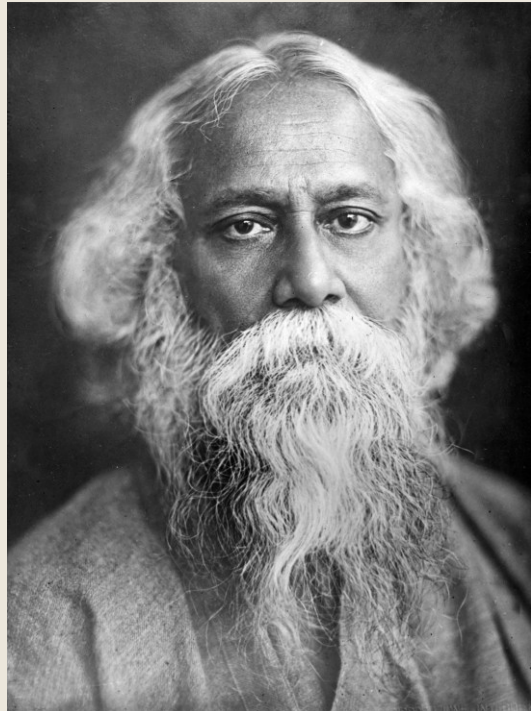


Image source: Encyclopaedia Britannica

04

Rabindranath Tagore

Shantiniketan



SHANTINIKETAN · VISVA-BHARATI

A whole person, formed through the arts

Suspicious of both colonial and rote indigenous schooling, Tagore built spaces — Shantiniketan, Sriniketan, Visva-Bharati — on the model of the ashram. Plays, music, festivals, and fairs dissolved the false split between aesthetic and academic education, and women joined boys in every activity of the school.

Lal 1984 · Gupta 2002 · O'Connell 2011

THINKER 05 / 06

Jiddu Krishnamurti

1895 – 1986

The school as a space free of *conditioning* —
and free, finally, of the self.

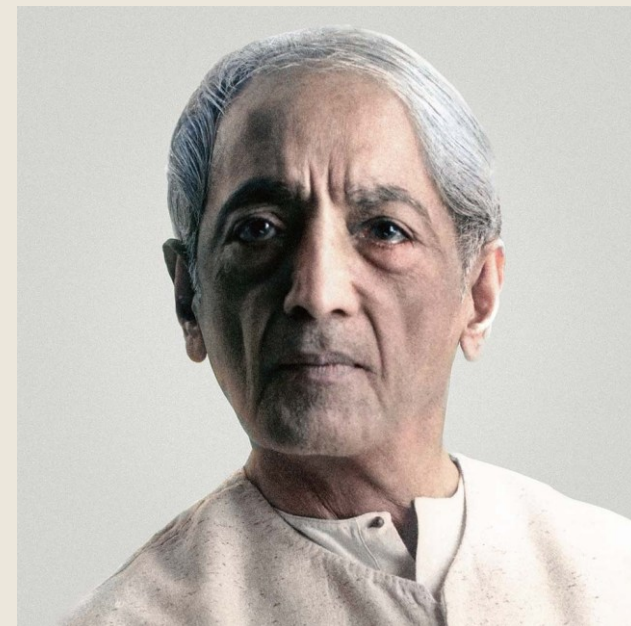
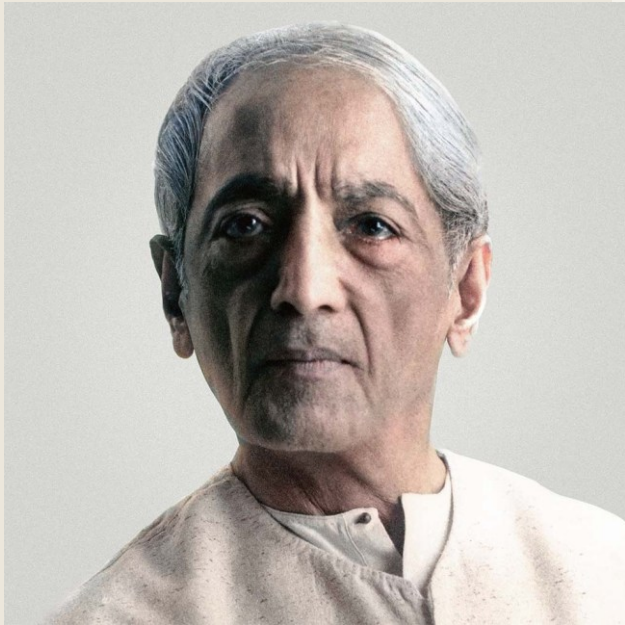


Image source: <https://kfoundation.org/>

05

Jiddu Krishnamurti

1895–1986



A SCHOOL WITHOUT CONDITIONING

“To think for oneself — to go beyond oneself.”

Schools should be playgrounds of free expression and critical inquiry, never instruments of conditioning. Assessment compared a student only with their own past; silence and self-understanding were valued. “To be integrally intelligent means to be without the self” — education frees the mind to discover truth “from moment to moment.”

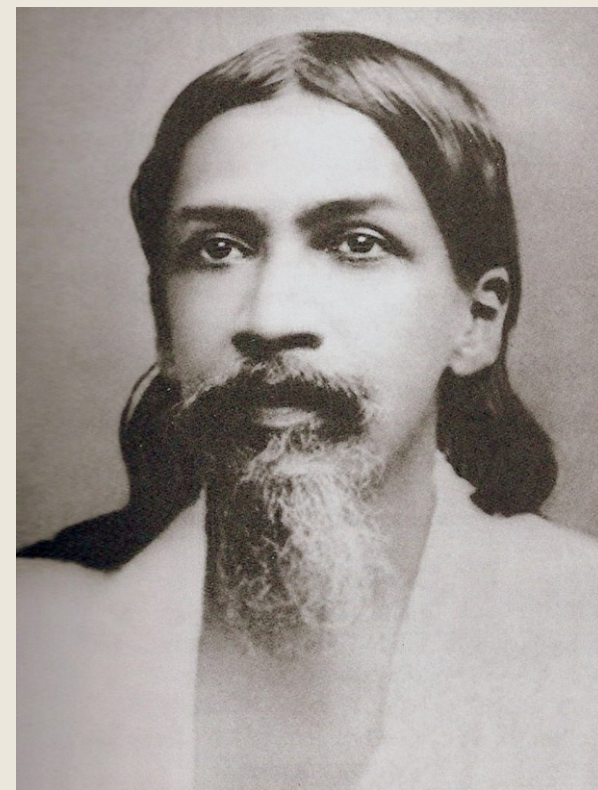
Krishnamurti 2002, p. 54 · Baniwal 2018 · Vittachi et al. 2007

THINKER 06 / 06

Sri Aurobindo

1872 – 1950

An *integral philosophy* — the social-political and the spiritual in one continuum.



SRI AUROBINDO

Source: Wiki

06

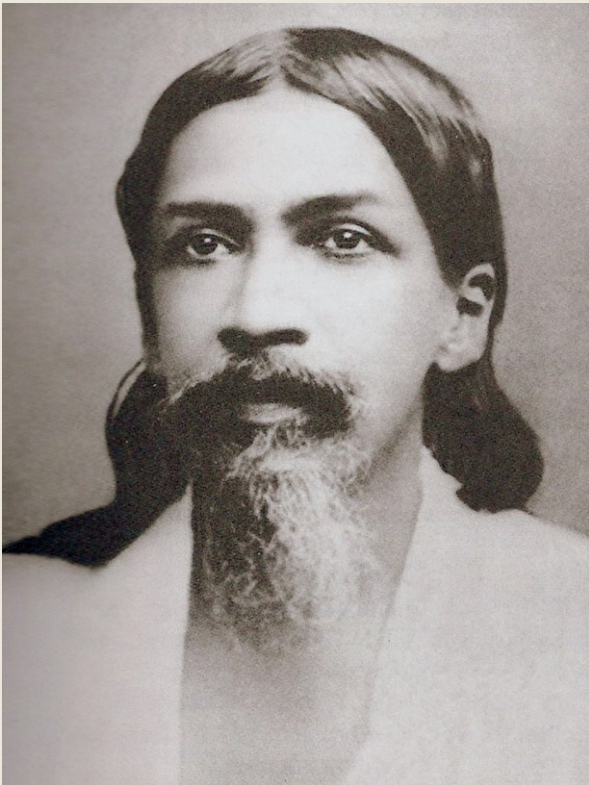
Sri Aurobindo

Integral education

THREE PRINCIPLES OF EDUCATION

Helping a mind grow itself

- 01 “Nothing can be taught.” The teacher is not an instructor or taskmaster, but a helper and guide.
- 02 “The mind has to be consulted in its own growth.” Respect the pupil, whatever their age.
- 03 “Work from the near to the far.” From that which is, to that which shall be.



Sri Aurobindo 1997, p. 45 · 2003a, p. 393

I N S U M

One ideal, many paths

Gandhi

Swaraj fuses the political, the moral, and the spiritual in one.

Ambedkar

Eliminating inequality is inevitable for a truly democratic society — through the socio-political.

Vivekananda

Read texts of oneness to become truly educated — through religion.

Tagore

Shun narrow identities and embrace the universal — through the arts.

Aurobindo

A continuum of the social-political and the spiritual — through the evolution of consciousness.

Krishnamurti

Break from all rhetoric, Vedantic or political — rooted in the personal.
